

Photograph by **ARUN KUMAR**

Ideological Dominance

- **Bhagwat openly criticised the BJP's Modi-centric campaign, divisive rhetoric and neglect of RSS feedback, signalling growing tensions within the Sangh parivar**
- **His remarks pushed the BJP to realign its focus, so as to incorporate RSS priorities into electoral strategies and foster reconciliation**
- **Stressing cultural unity, he has decried OTT content as a source of "moral corruption" and also reignited debates on population control**

The Sangh reciprocated by re-engaging with BJP leaders, deploying its key functionaries to mediate disputes and influence election strategies in various states. Top RSS leader Suresh Soni is now working with BJP leaders in selecting their new chief.

Bhagwat's stance on guiding the BJP's political agenda was reflected in his statement this month, when he cautioned against reigniting religious disputes, emphasising that while the Ram temple was a matter of faith, further conflicts should be avoided. This aligns with his insistence on a broader unity, transcending divisions of caste, creed and language, while still remaining embedded within the Sangh's long-standing vision of a Hindu Rashtra.

Beyond this, the RSS chief's interventions on cultural politics have been equally forceful. In October, he decried the content on OTT platforms as a source of "moral corruption", prompting the Union information and broadcasting ministry to consider regulatory measures. This is part of his conservative credo and its broader push against those he calls "cultural Marxists and "woke people," who he says are undermining India's education and culture, promoting conflict and disrupting social cohesion.

Bhagwat's recent call for a critical reappraisal of India's decades-old population control approach again kept him in mainstream headlines, sparking many debates in policy circles and reaffirming the RSS chief's ideological sway over its political affiliate. ■